coinage bearing mint names ranging from Zabul through Balkh has led Rezakhani (2020) to propose that "Banji" might be an Arabicized corruption of "Pangul," one of the regional rulers named on the aforementioned coins. As for the Jewish merchant, Fischel (1965: 149–150) also relied on the figure as a point of departure for his analysis of the Judeo-Persian funerary inscriptions from Jam-Firuzkuh's Jewish cemetery, a small group of which were rediscovered in the 1960s, with more subsequently coming to light. Approximately seventy-four funerary markers – carrying a total of at least ninety-one Judeo-Persian inscriptions – were found over the course of several decades at a short distance from the famous *minar* of Jam-Firuzkuh, in the Jewish cemetery cut into the mountainside at Kushkak. They commemorated personages of different occupations, with dates of death starting in the early eleventh century and continuing through end of the twelfth. See also Habibi 1980: 42; Pinder-Wilson 2001: n. 37; Lintz 2008; Lintz 2009; Hunter 2010; Thomas 2018: 214ff. The tripartite mural inscription at Tang-i Azau, about 200 km east of Herat and also in the vicinity of Jam-Firuzkuh, is datable to the fourteenth century. Cf. Ball 2019: No. 1144. The implications of the existence of a Jewish community at Jam-Firuzkuh, *prior* to its designation as the Shansabanis' summer capital in the mid-twelfth century, are explored below.

64. Juzjani vol. I, 1963: 324–327 (trans. vol. I, 1881: 311–316); also Edwards 2015: 98.
65. Cf. Juzjani vol. I, 1963: 328, 331 (trans. vol. I, 1881: 318, 331); for a discussion of the relevant passages from Juzjani, see also Thomas et al. 2014: 139–140.
66. According to the local reports gathered by Thomas et al. (2014: 136, 139–140), the ruins of a mosque "over 100 years old" lie adjacent to the tower; its salvageable wooden elements – mainly pillar bases – have been incorporated in the new village mosque as a reminder of the no longer usable structure. (Incidentally, the mosque's dating to the nineteenth century is supported by the lines of poetry by the Turkish poet Hafiz Burhan (1897–1943) inscribed on the aforesaid wooden components.) The frequent association of *minar*s with mosques may hint at the replacement of an older structure in the nineteenth century. Moreover, the *minar* and mosque ruins are by no means the only probably historical remains in the vicinity: on an adjacent promontory lie the foundation stones of a ruined fortified palace, locally known as *qasr-i dukhtar-i malik* ("castle of the king's daughter").
67. Thomas et al. 2014: 138.
68. Cf. esp., e.g., Sourdel-Thomine 1960; Blair 1985.
69. Cf. Ball and Fischer 2019: 495–498; Ball 2020; and Volume II. The Sistan towers lack any remaining epigraphic data and so provide no indication of patron or date, but have been assigned stylistically to the eleventh (Pinder-Wilson 2001: 173) or twelfth century (O'Kane 1984: 100); the earlier date may be more credible based on the handling of the brick revetment, and the comparability of the towers' stellate plans to those of eleventh-century Saljuq tomb towers (e.g., Gunbad-i Qabus, dated by inscription to AH 399/1009 CE). Thus, there was more than one formal precedent within Afghanistan even for *minar*s. As with the Qasimabad *minar*, the Nad-i Ali tower did not figure in Fischer et al.'s documentation of Sistan's archaeological remains in